THE CLIMB-CHECK

Five questions that separate polished from true.

Fluent, formatted output reads like expertise. These five questions check whether it earned the climb.

> Run it on **any confident claim** — an AI answer, a study, the next vendor pitch, a student's brief, the AI-written case write-up someone hands you. Ten minutes, no new software.

THE FIVE QUESTIONS

1 Is the comparison fair?

The length trap, the apples-to-oranges baseline. *What is actually being held constant — and what isn't?*

2 Did they measure what they claimed?

Validated instrument? Any accuracy test? For a case: did it reason from *this* patient, or pattern-match to a type?

3 Who decided — and what's their stake?

Conflicted or independent judges? Whose voices produced this — and *whose were left out?*

4 What did the headline drop from the source?

Trace it back up the chain — claim → press release → paper → data. *Every hop strips a qualifier.*

5 What was my prior — and did it move?

Write it down *before* you ask. No prior on paper → no way to know whether you actually updated.

MOVE 1 A prompt is a program.

> *A prompt isn't a question — it's a* **program.** *You're programming a prediction engine with words.*
>
> JULES WHITE, VANDERBILT

You already know this discipline. An **OPORD** is five paragraphs; an **SBAR** is four. A good prompt is the same move — structure you curate, not a wish you toss.

MOVE 2 CO-STAR-E — a scaffold for the prompt.

A starting structure for the ask itself:

C **Context**
The background it needs. Who's asking, the setting, what's already true.

O **Objective**
The actual ask — the verb. What you want it to *do*, specifically.

S **Style**
How it should read. Structure, length, formatting, vocabulary.

T **Tone** / *Persona*
The register. Clinical or warm. Hedged or committed.

A **Audience**
Who's reading. Each reader pulls a different vocabulary.

R **Response**
The format back. Paragraph, table, list — a structured object you can use.

E **Examples**
Show, don't tell. One or two beats a paragraph of rules.

CO-STAR from Sheila Teo — GovTech Singapore's first GPT-4 prompt-engineering competition (2023). +E for Examples.

MOVE 3 The higher-leverage move: ground it in context.

CO-STAR-E gets you a clean prompt. The bigger lever is **context** — what you ground the model in. To audit a claim, give it two things: **the claim or paper** you're checking, and **the standard you want it judged against** — a methods text, run as an adversarial reviewer rather than a cheerleader.

> ### Thinking Clearly with Data
> The logic of evidence, end to end — what a comparison can and can't show. Bueno de Mesquita & Fowler.

> ### OpenIntro Statistics (free)
> The shared foundation — sampling, inference, what a p-value does and doesn't say. Or any stats text you trust.

> ### *Your favorite text — or a key methods paper — goes here.*
> Bring the standard you already rely on. The method is the same; the rubric is yours.

Works best when the standard is a **PDF**. Hand any PDF you own (or find open-source) to an AI of your choice and ask it to turn it into a **tight, chapter-by-chapter markdown extract**. That's what I do — then I point the audit at the markdown.

Then run a prompt like this — CO-STAR-E doing the work:

ADVERSARIAL AUDIT PROMPT

```
CONTEXT:  I'm auditing a claim, not defending it. Attached: [the paper/claim]
and [book.md], a methods text I trust as the standard.
OBJECTIVE: Using [book.md] as the rubric, list every assumption the work makes
— explicit and implicit — and check each against the book. Then separate what
was measured from what was claimed.
STYLE:    One finding per line. Cite the book chapter for each check. No praise
for the writing.
TONE:     Skeptical and even-handed. Argue both sides. Default to "the evidence
doesn't support that" when it doesn't.
AUDIENCE: A clinician who knows the subject but not the statistics.
RESPONSE: A numbered list. Tag each finding [the source's own data] /
[inference] / [needs outside evidence].
```

Stay skeptical, not cynical. The job was never to reject the tool — it's to keep asking the questions.

Dr. Jared Black — Army-Baylor / Graduate School Research & Education Symposium.
From the keynote *Simplicity on the other side of complexity.*